Forgiven People Forgive

Matthew 18:21-35 (KJV)

Scripture

Matthew 18:21-35

21 Then came Peter to him, and said, Lord, how oft shall my brother sin against me, and I forgive him? till seven times? 22 Jesus saith unto him, I say not unto thee, Until seven times: but, Until seventy times seven.

23 Therefore is the kingdom of heaven likened unto a certain king, which would take account of his servants. 24 And when he had begun to reckon, one was brought unto him, which owed him ten thousand talents. 25 But forasmuch as he had not to pay, his lord commanded him to be sold, and his wife, and children, and all that he had, and payment to be made. 26 The servant therefore fell down, and worshipped him, saying, Lord, have patience with me, and I will pay thee all. 27 Then the lord of that servant was moved with compassion, and loosed him, and forgave him the debt. 28 But the same servant went out, and found one of his fellowservants, which owed him an hundred pence: and he laid hands on him, and took him by the throat, saying, Pay me that thou owest. 29 And his fellowservant fell down at his feet, and besought him, saying, Have patience with me, and I will pay thee all. 30 And he would not: but went and cast him into prison, till he should pay the debt. 31 So when his fellowservants saw what was done, they were very sorry, and came and told unto their lord all that was done. 32 Then his lord, after that he had called him, said unto him, O thou wicked servant, I forgave thee all that debt, because thou desiredst me: 33 Shouldest not thou also have had compassion on thy fellowservant, even as I had pity on thee? 34 And his lord was wroth, and delivered him to the tormentors, till he should pay all that was due unto him. 35 So likewise shall my heavenly Father do also unto you, if ye from your hearts forgive not every one his brother their trespasses.

Outline

1. Forgiveness does not keep count

Jesus told Peter to forgive not seven times, but _____ times seven.

Forgiveness that keeps _____ is waiting for the day it can stop.

Read: Matthew 18:21-22; Luke 17:3-4; Colossians 3:13

2. We have been forgiven a debt we could never pay

The servant owed a debt he could _____ repay.

The king forgave the whole debt because he was moved with _____.

Read: Matthew 18:23-27; Psalm 103:10-12; Ephesians 1:7; Romans 5:8

3. Forgiven people forgive from the heart

We forgive others because God has first _____ us.

Jesus asks us to forgive from the _____, not only in words.

Read: Matthew 18:28-35; Ephesians 4:32; Matthew 6:14-15

Discussion questions

1. Why do you think Peter offered the number seven? What does that tell us about how we usually think of forgiveness?

2. Compare the two debts in the story. What is Jesus teaching by making the first one so huge?

3. The servant was forgiven but did not become forgiving. How can a person receive mercy and stay unmerciful?

4. What is the difference between forgiving someone and trusting them again?

5. What makes forgiving "from the heart" hard, and what helps?

This week

This week, think of one person you have been "keeping score" against. Pray for them by name each day. Ask God to help you let go of the debt in your heart. If it is right and safe to do so, take one step toward peace: a kind word, a note, or a phone call.